

A

What do we mean by word partners?

If you want to use a word naturally, you often need to know other words that are commonly used with it. These are called word partners or collocations, and they can be different from language to language. For example:

I **spent time** in Paris. (NOT I passed time in Paris.) I **missed the bus**. (NOT I lost the bus.)

We **have** children. (NOT We get children.)

I **made** a mistake. (NOT I did a mistake.)

It was a **serious injury**. (also a **serious illness**)

It's **quite likely** that we'll stay here.

[we'll probably stay here]

It **depends on** my parents. (NOT It depends of my parents. See [Unit 77](#).)

Language help

More *word partners* can be found in the *Cambridge Learner's Dictionary* for intermediate learners and the *Cambridge Advanced Learner's Dictionary*.

B

Verbs and nouns

There are many verbs and nouns that are often used together.

Pavel **told** me a **joke** but I can't remember it. [told me a funny story]

I need to **lose weight**. [become less heavy; *opp* **put on weight**]

The doctor told my father that he should **go on a diet**. [eat less in order to lose weight]

It's very difficult to **predict the future**. [say what will happen in the future]

We won the game 2–1, and my brother **scored** the first **goal**¹.

My neighbour's **alarm went off**² in the middle of the night.

They **fell in love** and got married. Now Emily is **expecting a baby**³.

1



2



3



C

Adjectives and nouns

Many adjectives and nouns are often used together. These are all examples where the meaning is 'big' or 'a lot', but where we usually use a particular adjective.

We've got a **large number** of students/tourists this year. (*opp* a **limited/small** number)

I will need a **large amount** of money.

There's a **wide choice** of food available. (*opp* a **limited/narrow** choice)

Sergio has a **wide vocabulary** in English. (*opp* a **limited vocabulary**)

It's only a toy gun but it makes a very **loud noise**.

Her family is of **great importance** to her.

We went to a party last night and it was **great fun** [very enjoyable; we enjoyed it a lot].

There was **heavy traffic** on the motorway going out of town. (*opp* **light** traffic)

D

Adverbs and adjectives

The adverbs in the first three sentences mean *very*, the adverbs in the last sentence mean *fully/completely*. In each case, the adverbs and adjectives are common word partners.

I'm **terribly sorry** I'm late.

She's **well aware** of the problem. [She knows all about the problem.]

It's **vitaly important** that we get the right person for the job.

Ava is **fast asleep**, but the other two are still **wide awake**.